

STUNNING
DEBUT: Adiga



balance between the sociology of the wretched place he has chosen as home and the twisted humanism of the outcast. With detached, scatological precision, he surveys the grey remoteness of an India where the dispossessed and the privileged are not steeped in the stereotypes of struggle and domination. The ruthlessness of power and survival assumes a million moral ambiguities in this novel powered by an India where Bangalore is built on Bihar.

It is written as a letter from an entrepreneur in Bangalore to the Chinese premier on the eve of his Indian visit. What emerges from the letter that spans over seven nights is a portrait of a man and his country. The man: a fugitive from Darkness ("India is two countries in one: an India of Light, and an India of Darkness") who has seamlessly blended into the stream of light. The country: an India permanently taunted by 'Why can't we be like China?' and a land without justice—or mercy. The letter writer, the white tiger, "the creature that comes along only once in a generation", turns his transition from the heart of darkness—Laxmangarh in Gaya, the land of the Buddha as well as the Great Socialist who knows how to make the son of a Dhanbad don hold the spittoon for him—to the throbbing centre of light into a fable of the new India.

The White Tiger is the back story of an escapee from the Rooster Coop, "the greatest thing to come out of this country in the ten thousand years of its history." The roosters in the coop the narrator finds in the meat shops in Old Delhi "see the organs of their brothers lying around them. They know they are next. They do not rebel. They do not try

to get out of the coop. The same thing is done with human beings in this country". In the beginning, he is one of the wretched and the nameless, just Munna, on the Ganga, the black river of death which he has rejected after the last journey of his mother. The rickshaw-puller's son gets a name, and Balram Halwai becomes the brightest in the school. He becomes one of the spiders—the boys who wipe tables and crush coals—in a teashop. He learns the facts of life by eavesdropping. In Dhanbad, he gatecrashes into the house of a don and gets a job as a driver. His life as a servant flourishes in Delhi as he becomes the part-time conscience keeper of the don's son, his master, his aspiration, and his victim. Life inside a Honda City can't be more fantastic—and fatal. And Adiga—a former *Time* reporter from Delhi who now lives in Mumbai—as a storyteller drives on the fourth gear.

It is easy to read *The White Tiger* as a morality tale—and as a rejoinder to an India where the perversion of politics is only matched by the pornography of wealth. There is protest, anger, disgust and a sense of compassion. Still, the morality of the underdog offers little consolation in a country with a dark core. Killers on the run are good storytellers; they invent, play Scheherazade, and exaggerate memory. (Remember the wicked recipes of the protagonist of John Lanchester's first novel *The Debt to Pleasure*?) What the white tiger tells the Chinese premier in so many mesmerising words is that he is a rare creature, not as ordinary as 'Made in China'. He is rare indeed—in fiction. And Aravind Adiga has only begun the story.

pation. India, currently perhaps the most anatomised item on the writer's table, deserves such an intervention. It does more than break the monotony, the tedium of aspiration. Aravind Adiga, at 33, steps out of the highway of 21st-century India, takes a vantage position on the sidewalk, and, as a country of 36,000,004 gods and maybe more dreamers and doers who are all set to breach the borders and conquer the world zooms past before his eyes, blinks. *The White Tiger* is a novel born in that infinitesimal moment of darkness. And as a debut, it marks the arrival of a storyteller who strikes a fine

EXCERPT

For the Desk of:

His Excellency Wen Jiabao,
The Premier's Office,
Beijing,
Capital of the Freedom-Loving Nation
of China

From the Desk of:

"The White Tiger"
A Thinking Man
And an entrepreneur
Living in the world's centre of
technology and outsourcing
Electronics City Phase 1 (just off Hosur

Main Road),
Bangalore, India

Mr Premier,
Sir,

Neither you nor I speak English, but there are some things that can be said only in English.

My ex-employer the late Mr Ashok's ex-wife, Pinky Madam, taught me one of these things; and at 11:32 p.m. today, which was about ten minutes ago, when the lady on All India Radio announced, 'Premier Jiabao is